

DATA309-25S2

How to write a Project Brief

Purpose

The project brief needs to serve multiple purposes:

1. To be a record of what you understand your project to be at this point in time. It is bound to be somewhat naive and simplistic but you need to capture as much of your knowledge as possible.
2. To be a definition of what a successful outcome will look like. You need to explain how to measure the success of the project.
3. To be a checklist by which your final report can be compared - what you thought you would achieve versus what you actually achieved.

A well written project brief can serve the basis as your project report Introduction.

Audience

The language and detail you employ should suit an audience that is at the level you were at before you started on the project. Try to avoid domain specific jargon or explain each the first time you use it.

Length

Your brief should be as long as it needs to be. As a guide, about 2 to 3 pages of text is about the mode. Diagrams are welcome.

Sections

Each project is unique so it is difficult to define a template that suits all projects. The following sections in your brief are recommended to you:

Domain

Describe the field that you are working in and the organization you are working with. Does it have special challenges?

Goal

Describe the business / research goal(s) of the project. In addition, can you rephrase these goals into a set of data science objectives? What are the priorities of these goals if time does not allow all of them to be achieved?

Data

Describe the data you will be using:

- Where does it come from? Who produced it / owns it? How was it produced?
- Summarise the data e.g. 1200 observations of 17 variables that are a mixture of text, factors and numeric
- Discuss any particular data challenges e.g. high correlation, biased sample, imbalanced, missingness, multiple database tables etc. that you know of in advance

Planning

What are the tasks/steps that the project can be broken into? Do these steps have a logical order? What contingencies do you need to plan for? Can these steps be achieved in the time available?

Resources

Describe any special resources that are needed for the project. For example, databases, GPU, particular methods, research papers, special software etc. Describe the options available to you in this project e.g. Python / R / Julia and how you will choose an option.

Constraints

Describe any special constraints that apply to the project e.g. the data must not leave the organisation, the data cannot be sent to internet APIs for processing due to privacy commitments.